



PTI

SINCE ELITE POLE VAULTERS USUALLY COMPETE EITHER IN EUROPE OR THE USA, THEY JUST KEEP ONE SET OF POLES IN EACH CONTINENT

clubs or a cricket bat. Even if every pole looks the same — poles vary by length and stiffness — everything feels off when you use one that's not yours."

Even then, success is not guaranteed. "It's still possible that even if you manage to bring your own poles, you fail to make a clearance in competition. When I think about that, sometimes the hassle of carrying a pole seems more than the benefit. I think it's even more of a trade-off for me compared to a dedicated pole

vaulter, since this is just one of nine events I do. So, the return is much less than the risk or hassle. But at the end of the day, I don't think there's any real option but to go through all of this."

In all his years of competing, there's been just one time when Tejaswin didn't have to go through the stress.

"When I won silver at the Asian Games in Hangzhou, I got off the plane and a representative from Singapore Airlines told me my luggage had already arrived. I said

that's great, but I need my poles, and I knew that would take its own time. This time, though, my poles were already waiting for me. Someone even helped me carry them out of the airport. That showed me that I didn't have to go through all that procedure. But I guess it was different then, because they saw I was coming back as an Asian Games medallist. I guess that's some sort of motivation too — if I do well enough at a big enough competition, I'll just have my poles waiting for me when I get off the plane."